The Law

Purpose: *To demonstrate from scripture that God's law is all about love and liberty, that is to be internally written rather than externally imposed and it is eternal.*
Centered on: *The Decalogue.*

Matthew 22: 36-40…The law of God is all about love. The naturof the relationship is all about others…selflessness (1 Cor 13:4-6) Law =Love (i) imagine a city with perfect selfless goodness. This is a positive perspective of the law.

Romans 13: 10…Law = Love = No harm

James 1:25…Law = Liberty

Deut 5:29…Law = Wellness
Psalm 119:32…Law = Enlargement of my heart
(i) Learning an instrument…start burden..once mastered freedom

Ex 20:1…The law begins with I have brought you out of bondage. Passover/Cross sacrifice (Gal 5:1..you are free from what Christ has done for you.) 10 promises not regulations

Rom 3:20,28,31…The law brings about a knowledge of sin. Its not for salvation its for revelation. Our obedience doesn't save us its Gods grace.
Obedience flows out of salvation not salvation from obedience.

Rom 6:11-23…Salvation produces righteousness and obedience which comes from the heart.

Hebrews 8:10-12… v12 New covenant premised on the Mercy of God, (Rom 5:20..where sin abounds grace much more) v11 All will know God personally . v10 Law written in the heart and on the mind.

John 14:15…you will

Don't you see how God's law is a law of love and liberty of selflessness and what God has done for us.

Apologetics:

We must ask ourselves, is the writing of Gods law on the heart and mind of man, somewhat of a new paradigm?

Matthew 22: 35-40… Notice the reply from Jesus when questioned "which of the Commandments is the greatest". This text is often misapplied and interpreted as the Ten Commandments being abolished, and here after replaced by these "commandments of Christ". Is that what Jesus really meant?

Luke 10: 25-28… Here we find a similar discourse with another man knowledgeable in the law, however, Jesus in this instance takes a different course of action in his response. When the question was asked… *"What shall I do to inherit eternal life?"* With breathless attention the large congregation awaited the answer. The priests and rabbis had thought to entangle Christ by having the lawyer ask this question. But Jesus entered into no controversy. He requested the answer from the questioner himself. "*What is written in the law?*" He said; "*What is your reading of it*?" The Jews still accused Jesus of lightly regarding the law given from Sinai; but He turned the question of salvation upon the keeping of God's commandments. The lawyer said, *"you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your strength, and with all your mind; and your neighbour as yourself".* Jesus said, *"you have answered rightly; do this and you will live".*

In his answer as to the requirements of the law, he passed by all the mass of ceremonial and ritualistic precepts. For these he claimed no value, but presented the two great principles on which hang all the law and the prophets. This answer, being commended by Christ, placed the Saviour on vantage ground with the rabbis. They could not condemn Him for sanctioning that which had been advanced by an expositor of the law. He presented the law as a divine unity, and in this lesson taught that it is not possible to keep one precept, and break another; for the same principle runs through them all.

Deuteronomy 6: 5-6… Here God is summarising the principle behind obedience to his laws, furthermore, God is suggesting that his law be placed within the heart.

So as we can see, the idea of Gods Law being written on the heart of man is certainly by no means isolated to people of the New Covenant only. Jesus is merely bringing attention to the "locus of the law". This is clearly evident when we read the remainder of the passage…"*On these two Commandments (i.e. principles), hang all the law and the prophets*".

To gain further understanding of this misapplied text, we may consider the statement made by the apostle Paul at approximately A.D. 57….

Romans 13: 8-10…Note as Paul is giving direct quotes from the Decalogue, he then draws attention to the locus of these laws. *"Love is the fulfilment of the Law"!* Now if we apply that same method of thought to this statement as many of us do with the statement of Jesus, do we then nullify the previous two commandments of Christ, simply because Paul has now simplified the law even further? Of course not ******refer to illustration.**

If we have an understanding of the principles of the Ten Commandments, we will clearly see that they are centred on and around the principle of love!

Jesus could not have been any clearer when he stated *"I did not come to abolish/destroy the law but rather to fulfil'.* It was Christ's attitude and perfect obedience to the law of God that enabled him to be an appropriate sacrifice in the sinner's stead. Do we now make void the law due to this substitute?
"God forbid, we establish the law" (**Romans 3: 31**).

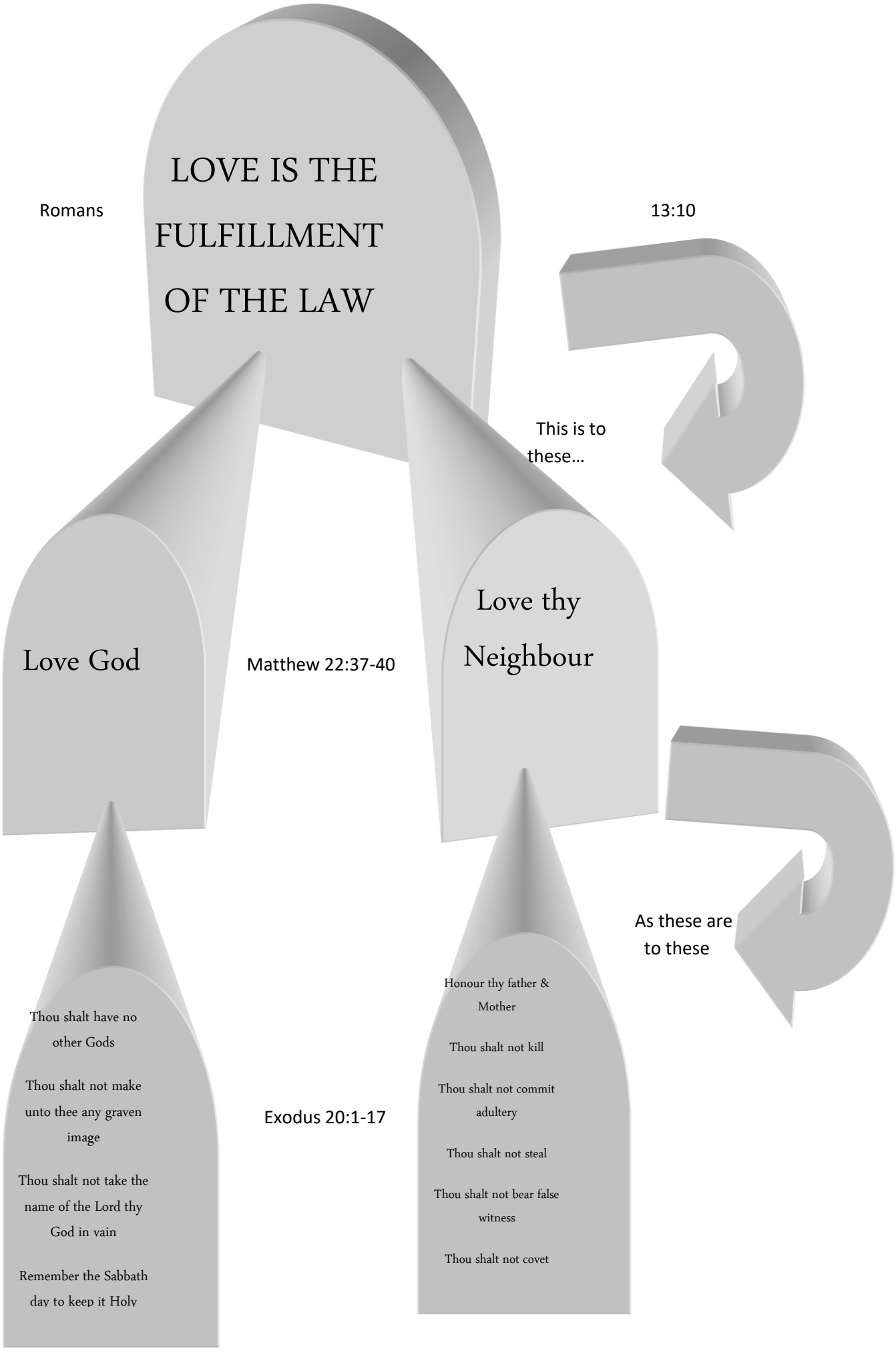
Additional Old Testament references which reveal the desire for God, to place his Law within the very *heart* of man.

Isaiah 51: 7…Those who "know righteousness" are here defined as having the law of God—a transcript of His character—in their hearts. His revealed will is etched upon their minds, and in character they are like Him (see **Gal 2: 20; Col 1: 27; 1 John 3: 2, 3**).

Deuteronomy 30: 6… *"Will circumcise thine heart".* To circumcise the heart means to quicken one's spiritual perception and make tender one's conscience. Compare: **Lev. 26:41; Jer. 31:33.**

Psalm 51: 10… **Create***:* Heb- *bara'* (see **Gen 1: 1**). God does not merely cleanse the heart; He creates in His forgiven child a new heart (see **Ezekiel 36: 26**). "The words, 'A new heart also will I give you,' mean, 'A new mind will I give you.' A change of heart is always attended by a clear conviction of Christian duty". The prayer for forgiveness should always be accompanied by the prayer for heart renewal and sanctification (see **Jer 24: 7; 11: 19; Rom 12: 2; Eph 2: 10; 4: 24**).

Psalm 37: 31… *"The Law of his God is…"* **Law**: Heb- *torah* (see **Prov 3: 1**).
"…In his heart". (See **Deut 6: 6; Ps 40: 8**). A new covenant experience (see **Heb 8: 8–13**).


LOVE IS THE FULFILLMENT OF THE LAW
Romans
13:10
This is to these…
Love God
Matthew 22:37-40
Love thy Neighbour
As these are to these
Thou shalt have no other Gods
Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image
Thou shalt not take the name of the Lord thy God in vain
Remember the Sabbath day to keep it Holy
Exodus 20:1-17
Honour thy father & Mother
Thou shalt not kill
Thou shalt not commit adultery
Thou shalt not steal
Thou shalt not bear false witness
Thou shalt not covet

Luther & Calvin

Western theology has been dominated by Martin Luther, and Luther pretty much hated Gods law. Most of the churches today are heavily influenced by Luther. The puritans on the other hand were influenced by John Calvin whom was an avid teacher and supporter of the law of God.

Romans 6: 14… According to this text, what does it mean to be under the law? What does it mean to be under grace? The context implies that salvation is achieved by grace and not the law! So Paul is simply making the statement that we are not saved by the law but rather saved by Grace. Of course! Telling saved people to keep Gods law is very different from telling people to keep Gods law in order to be saved. When we continue with the rest of the passage…

Romans 6: 15-16… Paul is not saying we should disregard Gods law! He is simply stating, ***Gods law is not the way to salvation*** rather it is through God's grace.

Romans 10: 4… According to this text:

Question: For what purpose is Christ the end of the law?

- **Answer:** For righteousness.

Question: For whom is Christ the end of the law?

- **Answer:** To all believers.

Therefore, Christ puts an end to a specific function of the law for believers, That is, ***believers do not use the law to gain righteousness*** but rather righteousness comes from Christ!

"For Christ is the end of the law"

The phrase "end of the law" could be understood as "termination of the law," suggesting that the law would no longer be in force. However, two matters must be considered: the context of the phrase and the Greek word for "end."

In this passage Paul is describing his fellow Jews who, to a great extent, have failed to reach salvation. They pursued the law of Moses, but not in faith, and failed to attain righteousness. In fact, they stumbled over the "Stumbling Stone." While attempting to become righteous through the law, they failed to see Christ as the one to whom the law of Moses, with its ceremonies and sacrifices, pointed (Rom. 9:30–10:4).

The word ***telos*** has a rich gamut of meanings: from termination to fulfilment to obligation to aim or goal. In the NT the basic meaning is tied to "fulfilment"; however, *telos* can also be translated as **aim or goal,** issue or result, end or conclusion. One should remember that purpose and result, aim and goal, are but two sides of the same coin. In ***1 Timothy 1:5***, telos is used in the phrase "the aim of our charge is love." That is, love is the intended result of our preaching. Thus, "end" (*telos)* In ***Romans 10:4*** can be seen to refer to Christ as the objective toward which the whole Jewish ritual or law pointed. Christ was the fulfilment of the OT figures and symbols, the culmination of the Torah, not the one who would abolish the law and end the validity of God's requirements for human beings.

Romans 7: 1-3…What has Paul spent a large amount of time saying in the previous chapter? ***Romans 6: 4***…we were buried with him through baptism into death. So Paul in this verse is saying "**you have died**." In ***Romans 7: 4-6***, Paul is saying when you die; you are then released from the law.

In regard to this text, you may hear people say, "I was baptized! When I was baptized I died, and this death released me from the law and now I'm married to Jesus so I don't have anything to do with the law of God anymore."

On face level, this may be seen as an excellent argument. But what is Paul actually saying? Sometimes we need to acknowledge what the writer is not saying in order to fully understand his message. Look at the last verse of ***Romans 7…***
So we find throughout Romans chapter 6 & 7, Paul is suggesting <u>three</u> things:

- I died to the law.
- I am released from the law.
- I serve the law.

Sadly, we often find people of one religious persuasion pushing for one aspect of Paul's teaching:
I am released from the law and I died to the law!
While yet another group of people are pushing for another aspect of Paul's teaching:
I serve the law!

Both of these groups need to figure out how we can say all three of these things, as this is the only true message Paul is trying to convey to his readers. Otherwise both groups are simply saying "we couldn't care less what Paul is actually saying."

So what does Paul mean when he said he died to the law?

Romans 7: 7-10 …Paul says I am released from the law! Therefore is the law a bad thing as he needed to be released from it? His answer is "**NO WAY**" in fact, it is of so extreme importance that if it had not been for the law, I would have not known sin and then he gives 1 of the commandments as an example. Interestingly he chooses the tenth. Coveting is the only commandment that happens only in the mind! For example, Jesus says you should not murder but further elaborates this to even not being angry. Jesus also said you should not commit adultery, and then he says adultery includes not even looking lustfully. So there is a physical way to violate the law and there is a mental way to violate the law. However, coveting happens only in the mind! So Paul is saying He didn't understand sin until the law came and showed him what sin really is. It has to do with the heart.
Note <u>verse 10</u> and then turn to ***Leviticus 18: 5.***

Leviticus 18: 5... This is the commandment that promised life! But what is the opposite of this? If you fail to keep the commandment you shall? So Paul was living his whole life thinking if he kept the commandments he would live, then one day he had an epiphany regarding the tenth commandment and realized that it is not just about how well I do on the outside but it also has to do with my heart. So now realizing he was actually violating the law, Paul says, the commandment that promised me life I found out was actually going to bring me death! So Paul realized he needed to be delivered from the law ***as a means of salvation*** and married to Christ as a means of salvation.

At the end Paul makes his point, I died to the law as a means of salvation! I am released from the law as a means of salvation! And now that I am married to Christ as a means of salvation he says…I serve the law of God with my mind.